

Josephine Auer

MIT Department of Economics, Cambridge, MA

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Research Fields

Primary: Microeconomic Theory, Behavioural Economics

Secondary: Industrial Organisation, Organisational Economics

Education

Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT)

Cambridge, MA

PhD in Economics, expected 2031

Current cumulative graduate GPA: 5.0/5.0

Kenan Sahin Presidential Fellow

University of Oxford

Oxford, UK

MPhil in Economics, 2023–2025

Distinction

Rhodes Scholar (Queensland and Magdalen College), University of Oxford

The University of Queensland

Brisbane, Australia

Bachelor of Mathematics, 2022 (GPA: 7.0/7.0)

Bachelor of Advanced Finance and Economics (Honours Class I), 2019 (GPA: 7.0/7.0)

Vice Chancellor's Scholar

Graduate Coursework

MIT Fall 2025 (completed):

14.164 Foundations of Behavioural Economics (A), 14.281 Contract Economics (A), ECON2059 Decision Theory (A), 14.271 Industrial Organisation I (listener)

MIT Spring 2026 (completed):

14.163 Algorithms and Behavioural Science, 14.283 Advanced Topics in Organisational Economics I, 14.284 Advanced Topics in Organisational Economics II, 14.126 Game Theory (listener), 14.273 Advanced Topics in Industrial Organisation (listener)

Research Papers

Under review

- *When Does Static Willingness to Pay Mislead? A Framework for Dynamic Hedonic Valuation*
- *A Secret Worth Keeping? Bid Cap Design in Budget-Constrained Procurement Auctions* (with Lana Friesen and Ian A. MacKenzie)

Research in Progress

- *AI and Skill Development in Frontline Health Work*: whether AI advice builds durable worker skill or mainly substitutes for knowledge at the moment of use.
- *Product Claims, Product Truth, and Consumer Demand*: a framework for measuring package communication relative to qualified product attributes and estimating its effect on differentiated-product demand.
- *Diagnosing Behavioural Hazard in the Age of Algorithms*: hypothesis generation from patient–chatbot data on why patients fail to undertake high-value medical care (with Zachary Wojtowicz).
- *Aggregate Rationalisability for Collective AI Systems*: a label-free audit for when aggregate AI recommendations can be rationalised by coherent latent role-level decisions.
- *Social Pivotality and False Consensus*: how public support changes the optimal order of persuasion by making later scrutiny socially costly and allowing consensus to form without full information aggregation.
- *Supernormal Stimuli*: a behavioural framework for how engineered cues amplify demand by making immediate benefits vivid and longer-run costs obscure (with Colin Camerer and Zachary Wojtowicz).
- *Modern Slavery*: a decision-theoretic analysis of risky migration and trafficking vulnerability under uncertainty (with Ian Jewitt).

Selected Policy Research Outputs

- Auer, J. (2022), *Disengaged: The costs and possible causes of youth disengagement in Australia*, e61 Research Note Series.
- Andrews, D., Auer, J., Elias, M., La Cava, G., and Mercier, L. (2022), *The effect of the COVID-19 recession on the youth labour market in Australia*, e61 Institute.
- Adams, N., Andrews, D., Auer, J., Clarke, E., Hayward, Z., La Cava, G., and Nolan, M. (2022), *Preventing scarring in the post-pandemic youth labour market*, e61 Institute.
- Adams, N., Andrews, D., Auer, J., Dwyer, E., Hayward, Z., Kaplan, G., La Cava, G., Michielsen, A., and Nolan, M. (2022), *Better harnessing Australia’s talent: five facts for the Summit*, e61 Institute.

Research Experience

University of Oxford, Economics of Modern Slavery Initiative Research Contributor	2024–present
e61 Institute Predoctoral Analyst	2022–2023
The University of Queensland, School of Economics Economics Research Assistant	2019–2022

Selected Honours and Awards

Kenan Sahin Presidential Fellowship, MIT, 2025–present
Rhodes Scholarship (Queensland), Oxford, 2023
University Medal, UQ, 2020
UQ Graduate of the Year, UQ, 2020
Valedictorian, UQ School of Economics, 2019
Vice Chancellor’s Scholarship, UQ, 2016–2022